

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles
Pentecost 11
Another Kind of Freedom ~ Healing Division
16 August 2026

LVF updated 1:30 Tuesday

Preaching: LVF

Worship Leading: ML & Lauren Seely

STRIPS OF PAPER IN PROGRAM FOR PRAYERS

Tech: we will need the piano for the offertory anthem, and one microphone for offertory solo. SOUND CHECK AT 8:45 AM

Organ Prelude-Concert

Dr. Emma Whitten, *Guest Organist*

Chiming of the Hour

[ML & Lauren center chancel]

Welcome

ML

Good morning and welcome to FCCLA, a place where all are welcome: welcome to be fully who we are, to love who we love, and to explore spirituality and faith at our own pace. Whether you are here in the Cathedral today, or online from around the country and around the world, we welcome you and are grateful for your presence. Our summer series, *Another Kind of Freedom*, continues today, as we explore the theme of *Healing Division*. Now, let all that divides us in heart, mind, body, and attention cease, as we open ourselves fully to the Sacred within and all around us, and join together in these Words of Gathering.

Words of Gathering

ML & LS

LS: We are inseparable from generations past
and generations future.

The lives of the ones who came before us
are present all around us.

The needs of those to come call upon us this day.

ML: What are we doing with all we have inherited -
the wonderful and the terrible?

What will we leave behind?

Both: *May the Holy things, the righteous things,
the things that make us brave in spirit
and fierce in hope*

*be our source of wisdom and guidance
as we strive to live faithfully-
to the Sacred
to each other
to those past and yet to come
in these perilous and precious days
we have been given.*

LS: May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!

[-enfleshed]

ML: *Please stand, in body or in spirit, for our Hymn of Gathering*

***Hymn of Gathering**

Holy Mystery

AUSTRIAN HYMN

 Holy Mystery_AUSTRIAN HYMN

Holy Mystery, Holy Wisdom, Wholly Love, who guides our way,
Loving Presence, Source of Being, now transform us day by day.
Words of Scripture tell our stories, voices rise in gifts of song,
Calling us to loving action, faith-filled as we journey on.

See the streams of living waters, springing from eternal love,
Wells supplying all that matters, and all fear of want remove;
Who can faint while such a river ever flows their thirst t'assuage?
Grace, which like our God, the Giver, never fails from age to age.

We are partners in creation, bound by love to all around,
Seeking justice and compassion, sharing truths that we have found.
Spirit - Source of Inspiration, Love - our song along the way,
Holy Mystery, Holy Wisdom –Source of hope with each new day.

[Michael center chancel]

***Prayer of Awareness and Confession**

ML

Let us pray together:

Holy One of freedom and liberation and reconciliation -
you have given us the law, spoken through prophets,
and provided us with the Spirit to help guide us
in love and justice.

Still we struggle.

The complexities of life and challenges of being human
often win over. In our pain we harm one another,
we do not intervene when our neighbors are targeted,
and we become possessive of power and resources.

Forgive us, O God.

And then, Gracious One,
ground our lives in mutual care and connection,
as we share with you - a vision of the belovedness
of each one of us, which is always and forever -
the cornerstone of your collective reality.

***For this and so much more, we are grateful.
Amen and Amen!***

[adpt/enfleshed]

***Introit**

Let All the World in Every Corner Sing

Ralph Vaughan Williams

Dr. Fahad Siadat, *Conductor*; Dr. Emma Whitten, *Organ*

[Lauren to lectern]

***The Lord's Prayer**

LS

Let us join together in this Lord's Prayer, adapted by enfleshed...

*Mother of us all,
who dwells within and beyond,
Sacred is your name.
May your holy vision for collective flourishing
come to fruition among us.
May your dreams of justice, love, compassion,
and connection be enfleshed on earth.
Provide us today with what we need to be nourished
in body, soul, and heart.
Forgive us for the harm we cause as we seek to
forgive those who have harmed us.
Lead us away from everything that destroys
and liberate us from the hands of evil.
For you are the ultimate source of hope.
Your power-with exceeds all power over.
Your presence incites eternal wonder.
All praise to you, our comfort and strength.
Amen and Amen!*

[-enfleshed]

[All turn towards altar]

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.

World without end, Amen, Amen.

[Michael center chancel]

***Passing of the Peace**

ML

In the center of the whirlwind
lies an eye.
Still.
Open.
Calm.
Before we come into the world,
it is as though we live in that center –
no worries,
no storms,
only peace.

As we find our way in **this** life,
even in the midst of chaos,
may we remember that center
and, as the need arises,
and it must,
may we hold
to the calm, open, stillness,
knowing it as home. [gvosper]

This morning, may the peace of God be with you.
And also with you.

Please be seated

[Lauren to lectern]

Reading from the Wisdom of Our Tradition

from the Gospel of Luke

LS

Hear now this reading from the Gospel of Luke, chapter 9...

As the time approached when he was to be taken from this world, Jesus firmly resolved to proceed toward Jerusalem and sent messengers on ahead. They entered a Samaritan town to make preparations for him, but the Samaritans wouldn't welcome Jesus because his destination was Jerusalem. When the disciples James and John saw this, they said, "Rabbi, do you want us to call down fire from heaven and destroy them?" But Jesus turned and reprimanded them. Then they set off for another town.

This is the Gospel of Grace.
Thanks be to God!

[Emma short transition Michael to center chancel]

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

In these moments...
we slow to the world,
taking a deep breath...
another...
and yet another...

We allow our spiritual gravity to bring us to rest
and find our place.
Remembering bubbles up.
We know this place...

Here...
we listen to our children and our elders,
laugh from the bottom of our belly,
heal and are healed by our neighbors,
touch the ones we love.
Here...
we recognize delight.

In being restored we remember
no effort is complete without the essential ingredient of
sacred rest. [adapt/wmuller]

As we share these moments of silence, we are invited to write down our gratitudes for life
and our prayers for our own lives and the life of our hurting world; wherever people are
cast out, overlooked, and experiencing isolation and violence.

Then, as the music begins, to come forward to offer our prayers here in this bowl and to
light a candle, signifying our prayers and our hope for healing and wholeness. If you're
with us online, we invite you to share your gratitude and prayers in our virtual prayer
bowl by emailing prayers@fccla.org.

Silence

**[After 2 minutes, Emma transition out of silence and play as people come forward to
offer prayers and light candles]**

Prayer of Our Hearts

Gracious and Holy One,
we gather this morning
opening to your healing power.
We do not understand all the things

that make us whole,
nor the mystery of all that hurts us in body,
mind, and spirit.

But we do know this:
that the presence of the Christ,
the hidden wholeness coursing
through your wondrous universe,
weaves, from the dropped threads of unfinished lives,
a fabric of unmatched beauty.
We come this morning, O God,
seeking less to understand this Healing Source
than to open ourselves
to its sacred flow,
released in us
through this simple act of gathering -
singing, praying, and holding one another and our
beautiful, but often broken world -
in your love.

This we pray.

Amen. [adapt/bsanguin]

[Emma transition small ensemble to positions]

Meditation Anthem *That Which Can't be Explained* Peter Eldridge/Arr. Katelyn Dietz
Katelyn Dietz, Chohi Kim, Frank Hobbs, Kion Heidari, David Conley, *Small Ensemble*
Rohan Ramanam, *Soloist*, Katelyn Dietz, *Director*

[Emma transition Laura to pulpit]

Sermon *Healing Division* **LVF**

[Emma transition Lauren to lectern]

Invitation to Generosity **LS**

In a spirit of openness and affirmation,
we bring our gifts now for the healing ministry of this place.

We are privileged to share a ministry of love and acceptance,
that flows to our community, and to our world.

We are grateful to be co-creating with God,
a place where all are welcomed and honored,
seen and heard, loved and fully known.

We do this through the liberating Way of Jesus, who made certain there was room for everyone at the Table of God's love.

This morning, with gratitude for the gift of life, we are invited to share from our resources for our Community Gardens & Urban Farm, as we continue to grow healthy, organic vegetables, fruits, herbs, and greens that nourish our surrounding communities.

You will find information for online giving in your programs and appearing now on your screens at home. Our Hospitality Team will come forward now to collect any gifts you have to share.

Gardens QR Code

Offertory Anthem

Bože! Bože! Pisen novou

Antonin Dvorák

Anna Caplan, Soloist, Dr. Emma Whitten, Organ

I will sing a new song unto thee, O God: upon a psaltery and an instrument of ten strings will I sing praises unto thee.

[All turn towards altar]

*Doxology

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!

Alleluia! Alleluia!

Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.

Alleluia! Alleluia!

Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!

[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

[Lauren to lectern]

*Offering Prayer

LS

Let us offer this prayer together:

Holy Mystery,

we pray this morning ---

mindful of all that has brought us together,

of the Spirit of Life at work in our lives,

and of what may be possible

if we allow this Spirit to work

freely in each of us.

*Let our generosity increase
as our lives are transformed
so that we may be
light and life in this place.*

Amen and Amen!

Please be seated

[Michael and Laura center chancel]

Life at First Church

LVF & ML

ML: Our gardens have acquired two cats to care for the space, lovingly trained by Michael Wickstrom. Last week, our youth named the cats and Ianthe informs us that these brilliant puns come directly from the teens themselves! Please welcome to our community the cats of Amanda Scott Gardens: Bartholomew Simpson the Third, and Meowy Magdalene, middle name Jalene: representing the first initial of each of the youth's first names.

Words of Blessing

LVF

Today we have gathered our courage in community because...

We can do hard things

Brave things

Beautiful things

Risky and transformative things.

The Sacred travels with those who journey toward freedom.

For the sake of the collective life

For the sake of disrupting evil

For the sake of the human soul.

We are called and companied,
never really alone.

*May our hearts be encouraged both this day -
and in all the days to come.*

[-enfleshed]

Amen and Amen!

Choral Response

Amen

Kelly McCandless

So let it be. So it shall be. Let us love one another. Amen.

***Hymn for the Journey**

Come Now, O Wisdom

SLANE

 **Come Now, O Wisdom (SLANE).pdf**

Come now, O Wisdom, we need your clear voice;
Speak and awaken our hearts to rejoice.
Gracious Creator of more than we know,
In your own image may we ever grow.

Come now, O Wisdom, abide in our souls;

Stir in us visions of life free and whole.
Wisdom, your pathway to justice and peace,
With you our dreams find their fullest release.

Wisdom, more precious than rubies or gold;
With you our graces forever unfold.
No fame or fortune with you can compare;
Pour out your blessings, so rich and so rare.

Wisdom your grace joins all heaven and earth;
With you we labor new life to give birth.
Come now, O Wisdom, our Midwife and Friend,
Open our hearts to your world without end.

-lyrics by Jann Aldredge-Clanton

[Michael center chancel]

Postlude

Dr. Emma Whitten, *Guest Organist*

Inside the Music - Dr. Ianthe Marini

In our musical exploration today of *healing division*, we focus on that which unites us. We begin with the call for unity —*let all the world in every corner sing*— composed by the prominent 20th century British progressive social activist Ralph Vaughan Williams, whose work was informed by his ideals that the healing properties of music should be accessible for all and not reserved for the economic elite. We hear the urgency in his invitation through the insistence of the organ line and the rhythmic pulse of the choral homophony. Sometimes *love* sounds rousing! We meditate on the theme of healing with the tune and poem *That Which Can't be explained* by Peter Eldridge, arranged by Laude's own Katelyn Dietz. In it, the singer inquires about *differences unreconciled*, questions of *shaky refuge*, and the agnostic presence of spirit, connecting always to *loving that which can't be explained*. Sometimes *love* sounds intangible and uncertain!

Anna and Dr. Whitten then offer us an exclamation of praise from Psalms 144 and 145, *singing a new song unto the Earth with voice and strings*. Sometimes *love* sounds celebratory! And finally, we sing *Amen* —*let it be so*— in the Kelly McCandless sonic poem which explores the meaning of the word. In it, she discovers that *Amen*, to her, means *so let it be—so it shall be—we shall be who we are, one in the spirit*. *Let us love one another—Amen*. Sometimes, *love* sounds like radical acceptance and the healing of division.